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INTRODUCTION

> Pim, non ci sono gli archetipi, c'è il corpo. Dentro la pancia è bello perché ci cresce il bambino, si infila il tuo uccellino tutto allegro e scende il cibo buono saporito, e per questo sono belli e importanti la caverna, l'anfratto, il cunicolo, il sotterraneo, e persino il labirinto che è fatto come le nostre buone e sante trippe, e quando qualcuno deve inventare qualcosa di importante lo fa venire di lì, perché sei venuto di lì anche tu il giorno che sei nato, e la fertilità è sempre in un buco, dove qualcosa prima marcisce e poi ecco là, un cinesino, un dattero, un baobab. Ma alto è meglio che basso, perché se stai a testa in giù ti viene il sangue alla testa, perché i piedie puzzano e i capelli meno, perché è meglio salire su un albero a coglier frutti che finire sottoterra a ingrassare i vermi, perché raramente ti fai male toccando in alto (devi essere proprio in solaio) e di solito ti fai male cascando verso il basso, ed ecco perché l'alto è angelico e il basso diabolico.
>
> Umberto Eco, *Il pendolo di Foucault*, Milan 1988, 287

The human body exists in a unique field of overlaps, transcending such familiar and deep-rooted dichotomies as culture and nature, individual and society. The ancient Egyptian body in its tangible, ritualized form as a mummy stresses this ambiguous status by blurring the dichotomy between human and object.[1] Embalmed and wrapped in linen, the mummy offers a silent contradiction of these categories. Ritualized and wrapped in texts, the mummy is the key to understanding the categories with which it was described by the ancient Egyptians.

Written literally surrounding the deceased, the Coffin Texts are found in a distinctly bodily environment. By their placement, the texts enter into a complex spatial relationship between the body in the coffin, the coffin decoration (including depictions of objects in friezes) and the tomb into which the coffin is put (including such macrocosmic considerations as orientation according to cardinal points and geographical location). Consequently, it is not surprising to find that the texts themselves are full of references to the body and its parts, most usually that of the ritual persona of the deceased presented in the Coffin Texts spells. The overarching concern is with such basically somatic themes as unity versus fragmentation and functionality versus lack of functionality. The texts treat the ritual acts of mummification and the material function of the coffin as a tangible means of maintaining the unity and structure of the body.

In ancient Egyptian funerary texts, the destruction of the body by fragmentation belongs to the most prominent ways of characterizing death as an opposition to life.[2] The condition of the body of the deceased thus becomes both a salient index and an indispensable precondition for the passage from a living human being to a deceased ancestor. When the perspective is shifted from the human body as a whole to its individual parts, a similar concern with their proper location and function becomes apparent. Again,

---

[1] Cf. the discussion and references in Meskell, *Object Worlds*, 124-130.
[2] Cf. the characteristically titled chapter 1 "Der Tod als Zerrissenheit" of J. Assmann's *Tod und Jenseits*.

death is seen as displacement and destruction of vital functions – defects which ritual seeks to correct. The study of the threats against the body parts thus provides insights into their proper function, often in a way unparalleled in e.g. the medical texts.

The role of the body in mortuary texts is not, however, limited to the treatment and restoration of the body of the deceased. Transformations offer the possibility of the creation of entirely new bodies, bodies are merged and separated, conceived, born and consumed, and once we start looking for them, bodies and their parts seem to turn up in the most unexpected places in cosmology and mythology.

This book examines the body and bodies as locus for the manifold processes taking place within it and between them in the Middle Kingdom mortuary literature. Studying embodiment and conceptions of the body in an ancient culture raises a number of methodological questions concerning the way in which the sources are viewed and analyzed, and even more fundamentally, how the very object of study, the human body, is conceived in the mind of the modern observer and reader. A tempting and well-tried avenue of approach is to establish a set of correspondences between ancient terminology and that of modern biomedicine. Once this has been accomplished, it becomes easy to evaluate the relationships between the anatomical entities. In this approach it becomes necessary to identify those parts of the ancient sources that do not meet the standards of empirical science.[3] The material excluded in this way can then be studied in terms of symbolic relationships and the like, employing a completely different methodology.

This mixture of apparently diverse elements has made it difficult to establish a set of analytical terms that accommodates both perspectives. Thus, it seems that a study of ancient Egyptian conceptions of the human body must first determine whether to focus on the terminology that is comparable to modern biomedical models or on the concepts found in the magical components based on associations with mythological events.

There are, however, also aspects that are much more basic than either the medical or the magical viewpoints – and which may provide the means to bridge the gap. I am referring to the body as locus of lived experience. If we recognize that the practical observations of the ancient Egyptian papyri are secondary in relation to the individual experience of one's own body as the means of being-in-the-world, then the study of the conception the human body requires an approach that differs from those traditionally used.

Of paramount importance for the development of the "paradigm of embodiment" referred to above has been the philosophical school of phenomenology. From the phenomenological perspective, it becomes apparent that the tacit assumption that the body, being a material object, is best understood within the framework of biomedical science imposes a highly problematic dualism on sources that may not share it and raises the methodological question whether this can be avoided. Apart from having led anthropologists to ask a whole range of new questions, phenomenology has also had a profound influence within the cognitive strand of linguistics, and in the methodology of this

[3] Cf. e.g. the limitation of the inclusion of magical spells to "das uns medizinisch wesentliche Erscheinende" in *GdM* IV/1, vi.

particular field, we find a number of concepts that will prove particularly useful for studying conceptions of the body in ancient texts without reducing these to more or less felicitous forerunners of modern biomedical models.

Chapter 1 reviews the theoretical concepts applied in this study in some detail, beginning with the important notions of image schemata, conceptual metaphors, idealized cognitive models and prototypes as understood in cognitive linguistics. The second part of this chapter deals with the phenomenological views of the human body very briefly outlined above and the methodological consequences that can be drawn from these.

The remainder of the book is divided into three parts, the structure of which is partially dependent on the theoretical notions introduced in chapter 1. For this reason a more detailed sketch of the disposition of the work will be found at the end of that chapter.

The first part of the book, chapters 2-7, presents the conceptualization of the individual body parts that occur in the corpus. The basic method is lexicographical. The occurrence of each body part is collected, classified and characterized. The attributes used in this classification are derived from a cognitive linguistic framework, so that focus is on the identification of the main image schemata used to structure the concept, the kind of metaphors in which the body part is used and the prototypical attributes ascribed to it. In a few cases, notably the "heart"-terms discussed in chapter 2, a more thorough lexicographical discussion is necessary, including a detailed overview of earlier interpretations of the terms. This discussion attempts to clarify particular long-standing questions addressed in the analysis.

While the first part focuses on individual body parts, the second deals with some select examples of the interplay between them and with some selected notions of more general relevance. Chapters 8 and 9 deal with important idealized cognitive models that include more than one body part as well as typically some sort of bodily "substances", such as knowledge or magic.

The third part, consisting of chapter 10, moves a step further in examining prototype conceptions of the human body in more general terms than what is expressed in statements about the individual body parts and in the models for individual powers and processes. This chapter also broadens the perspective by giving a few examples of the relation between notions of embodiment in the Coffin Texts and those found in other types of texts.

A note on citations

The focus on the conceptual structure of the Egyptian sources entails keeping the translations as literal as possible in order to retain as much of this structure as possible. For this reason, a wording close to that of the original Middle Egyptian has been chosen over an elegant English translation. In some cases this extends to an improper use of English prepositions when it is considered important to emphasize particular linguistic structures in Egyptian expressions, which do not transfer well to English.

In translations of primary sources, rubrics are marked with *italics*, while in transliterations, they are marked with ***bold italics***. The system of bracketing is kept relatively simple, []

marks a lacuna, () indicates an explanatory note, <> an emendation, and {} signs to be deleted from the original. The insertion of … between brackets marks an omission or lacuna, without being an indication of its length.

In quotations from secondary sources, [] marks an explanatory note by the present author, while (…) marks an omission of part of the original text. Footnotes inserted in quotations are remarks by the present author, rather than notes found in the original.